



Alien Guitar Secrets

LESSON 7.3 DROP CHORDS

WHAT ARE DROP CHORDS?

A **drop chord** is a method of rearranging the notes of a chord to create more open voicings. Drop chords spread the chord tones across a wider range, resulting in a balanced, full sound. The primary focus will be on **Drop 2** and **Drop 3 voicings**, which are the most commonly used variations.

- **Closed Voicing:** All the chord tones are as close together as possible (e.g., C-E-G-B for Cmaj7).
- **Drop Voicing:** A specific note in the chord is dropped down one octave to create a more spacious sound.

DROP 2 CHORDS

A **Drop 2 chord** takes the **second-highest note** in a closed voicing and drops it down one octave.

Example: Cmaj7 (Root Position)

- **Closed Voicing:** C (1) - E (3) - G (5) - B (7)
- **Drop 2 Voicing:** G (5) is dropped down an octave.

Resulting Notes:

- G (5th) - C (root) - E (3rd) - B (7th)

APPLICATIONS OF DROP 2 CHORDS

- **Comping:** Drop 2 voicings are ideal for comping behind soloists because they sound open and don't clash with the melody.
- **Smooth Voice Leading:** These voicings transition seamlessly between chords in progressions like ii-V-I.
- **Genres:** Commonly used in jazz, blues, R&B, and even pop music.



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DROP 3 CHORDS

A **Drop 3 chord** takes the **third-highest note** in a closed voicing and drops it down one octave.

Example: Cmaj7 (Root Position)

- **Closed Voicing:** C (1) - E (3) - G (5) - B (7)
- **Drop 3 Voicing:** E (3) is dropped down an octave.

Resulting Notes:

- E (3rd) - C (root) - G (5th) - B (7th)

APPLICATIONS OF DROP 3 CHORDS

- **Solo Guitar Arrangements:** Drop 3 voicings are bass-heavy and ideal for solo performances.
- **Walking Basslines:** The lower note provides a strong bass foundation.
- **Genres:** Commonly used in solo jazz guitar, classical guitar, and fingerstyle arrangements.

PRACTICAL EXERCISES

Exercise 1: Convert Closed Voicings to Drop 2 and Drop 3

1. Start with a **Cmaj7 closed voicing**: C (1), E (3), G (5), B (7).
2. Create the **Drop 2 voicing** by lowering the second-highest note (G) by an octave.
3. Create the **Drop 3 voicing** by lowering the third-highest note (E) by an octave.

Exercise 2: Play ii-V-I Progressions with Drop Chords

- In the key of **C major**:
 - ii: Dm7 (Drop 2)
 - V: G7 (Drop 2)



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- I: Cmaj7 (Drop 2)
- Experiment with both **Drop 2** and **Drop 3 voicings** to hear the difference.

Exercise 3: Transpose to Different Keys

- Take a ii-V-I progression (e.g., Dm7 - G7 - Cmaj7) and transpose it to other keys using drop voicings.

Exercise 4: Combine Drop 2 and Drop 3 in Progressions

- Mix Drop 2 and Drop 3 voicings for a richer harmonic palette.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Drop 2 voicings:** Balanced, open-sounding chords ideal for comping and smooth transitions.
- **Drop 3 voicings:** Bass-heavy and lush, perfect for solo arrangements or walking basslines.
- **Practice Tip:** Focus on learning these voicings across different string sets and root positions to build flexibility.